Nils Handler

Economist · Climate Strategist · PhD Candidate

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About

Economist and strategist working at the intersection of climate policy, green public procurement, and data-driven institutional change. Over 13 years of international experience across decarbonization, carbon markets, and development economics — with postings at the World Bank, Inter-American Development Bank, and the Federal Institute for Geosciences and Natural Resources (BGR, Germany). Currently leading climate neutrality at the University of Zurich and a PhD candidate at the Berlin School of Economics (research stays at MIT Sloan, LSE Grantham, and Imperial College London). Founder of the d\carb Future Economy Forum.

Positions

Project Leader Climate Neutrality — Aug 2024 – present

Office of the President, University of Zurich — Zurich, Switzerland

– Leading evidence-based decarbonization agenda in collaboration with UZH Sustainability Hub, ETH Zurich, and Swiss university partners
– Developed concept for the world's first global university buyers club for durable CDR
– AI-enabled product carbon footprinting of procurement data via Terralytiq partnership
– Managing CHF 1.2M budget, 2 full-time data scientists, and 3 part-time direct reports

External Consultant — Mar–Jul 2024

BMW Foundation & GIZ (European Climate Initiative) — Remote

– Developed thematic approaches for BMWF's new leadership on energy resilience; >10 concept papers and briefings
– Reviewed project proposals for EUKI, scoring decarbonization potential, cross-border synergies, and developmental impact

Economist & Project Manager, International Cooperation — Sep 2018 – Jun 2021

Federal Institute for Geosciences and Natural Resources (BGR) — Hannover, Germany

– Led financial modelling of US$6.5B in climate-critical mineral procurement (copper & cobalt, Zambia & DRC); publicly recognized by Tableau
– Contributed economic modelling to Investing in Net Zero for Breakthrough Energy / Tech for Net Zero Alliance
– Presented LION-tool to Permanent Secretary of Ministry of Mines and German Ambassador in Zambia, resulting in cabinet briefing
– Budget oversight >€200K; OECD Natural Resource Policy Dialogue and high-level government stakeholder management

Economist, Energy, Trade & Competitiveness — Dec 2014 – Jun 2017

World Bank — Washington D.C., USA

– Led development of the Mining Investment and Governance Review (MInGov): quality control, budget planning, donor relations
– Mapped and analysed climate policies on green competitiveness across 25+ countries
– Organised global conference (>US$200K budget); led one of the World Bank's most active Communities of Practice

Consultant & Carlo Schmid Fellow — Sep 2012 – Nov 2014

Inter-American Development Bank (IADB) — Washington D.C., USA

– Quantitative and qualitative research on fiscal decentralization, extractive industries, and subnational revenue management; authored >10 internal policy publications
– Participated in Board Meetings; briefed Governors via constituency report for the Annual Meeting

Research & Writing

Working Paper · May 2026

Reducing Emissions in the Laboratory: Evidence from a Randomized Evaluation of a Sustainable Practice and Accreditation Scheme

Daphne Rutnam & Nils Handler (primary authors, order randomized) · Nicolas Harrington Ruiz · University of Zurich

We study a sustainability policy intervention targeted at research groups within university science faculties — a setting exhibiting a particularly severe principal-agent problem, where groups have high autonomy over energy-intensive activities but incur no direct costs for their electricity use. The policy combines sustainable practice guidelines, certification, and energy use calculators. Using a randomized controlled trial (RCT), we estimate its causal impact on research groups' energy use, attitudes towards sustainability, and beliefs about top-down climate initiatives. Preliminary findings indicate strong treatment uptake: 87% of treated groups achieved at least bronze certification and over 50% reached gold by endline. We find a significant positive effect on researchers' awareness of their group's energy and resource costs, and a significant negative effect on the belief that direct financial costs would be needed to motivate energy-saving action. We find no evidence of backlash against the sustainability policy. Results on energy use are forthcoming.

JEL: C93, D83, Q41, Q54 · Keywords: energy efficiency gap, field experiment, lab sustainability, information provision, certification · Preliminary draft

Working Paper · May 2026

Unlocking Innovation: Experimental Evidence on Barriers & Returns to Public R&D; Funding Uptake

Nils Handler · University of Zurich

Despite substantial public investments in R&D; subsidies, uptake rates remain surprisingly low, particularly among small and medium-sized enterprises. This study pursues two nested research questions through a single experimental design. Layer 1 identifies the causal barriers preventing eligible German firms from claiming the Forschungszulage R&D; tax credit — Germany's largest firm-facing innovation support program — by randomly assigning firms to an information intervention, an agentic AI-assisted application tool, both, or neither. Layer 2 exploits the randomized treatment assignments as instruments in a two-stage least squares (2SLS) design to estimate the causal effect of tax credit receipt on firm-level R&D; investment, thereby providing the first experimental IV estimate of the returns to a major European R&D; tax credit program. This research contributes to understanding information frictions and administrative burden in innovation policy, while testing novel AI-assisted interventions.

JEL: O31, O38, H25, C93 · Keywords: R&D; subsidies, information frictions, field experiment, innovation policy, AI, instrumental variables

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Stranded Nations? Transition Risks and Opportunities towards a Clean Economy

Pia Andres · Penny Mealy · Nils Handler · Samuel Fankhauser · LSE, Oxford, DIW Berlin, BSE

The transition away from a fossil-fuel powered economy towards a cleaner production system will create winners and losers in the global trade system. We compile a list of 'brown' traded products whose use is highly likely to decline if the world is to mitigate climate change, and explore which countries are most at risk of seeing their productive capabilities 'stranded'. Using methods from economic geography and complexity, we develop novel measures of transition risk that capture the extent to which countries' export profiles are locked-in to brown products. We show that countries exporting a high number of brown products, especially technologically sophisticated ones, could find it relatively easy to transition. Conversely, countries with exports highly concentrated in a few, low-complexity brown products have much fewer nearby diversification opportunities. Our results suggest that export complexity and diversity play a key role in determining transition risk. Path-breaking diversification strategies are needed to prevent nations from becoming stranded.

Keywords: green growth, fossil fuel, just transition, stranded assets, green competitiveness, economic complexity, diversification

Advisory Report

Investing in Net Zero: Assessing Germany's Venture Capital Potential in Climate Tech until 2030

Breakthrough Energy / Tech for Net Zero Alliance

Economic modelling of Germany's venture capital landscape for climate technology, assessing deployment gaps and sectoral opportunity across the path to net zero by 2030.

Teaching & Supervision

HEC Paris	Lecturer, MBA Climate & Business Certificate — "Climate Policy and Green Growth" (April 2023)
ETH Zurich	Executive training — climate strategy and green competitiveness
Hertie School	Executive training — energy transition policy, Berlin
Oxford / LSE	MSc dissertation supervision — Nigel Yao (Oxford, distinction), Lewis Morrey (LSE), Apurva Munjal (LSE)

Education

PhD Candidate in Economics 2019–present

Berlin School of Economics — intake <4%, fully funded

Environmental Economics · Energy Transition · Green Competitiveness. Research stays: MIT Sloan · LSE Grantham · Imperial College London. Committee: Prof. Marion Dumas (LSE), Prof. Ottmar Edenhofer (TU Berlin), Prof. Jan Steckel.

MSc International Trade, Finance and Development 2017–18

Barcelona Graduate School of Economics (top 10 worldwide)

MSc Political Economy of Late Development 2011–12

London School of Economics (LSE)

Distinction, top 5%

BSc International Economics & American Studies 2007–11

University of Tübingen

Exchange year: Universidade de São Paulo, Brazil (2009–10)

Honors & Fellowships

2023	Hans Weisser Fellowship — US Research Stay & Academic Networking
2022	Young Global Changer, Global Solutions Initiative
2020–24	Energy Transition PhD Fellowship, Academic Merit Foundation of German Businesses (top 1%)
2012–13	Carlo Schmid Fellowship — DAAD / German Academic Merit Foundation
2009–12	Scholarship, Academic Merit Foundation of German Protestant Churches
2003–04	Congress-Bundestag Scholarship — high school year, Bangor, Maine USA

Languages & Technical Skills

Languages	German (native) · English (C2) · Spanish (C2) · Portuguese (C2) · French (B1)
Methods	Econometrics · RCT design · Difference-in-differences · Instrumental variables · 2SLS · Economic complexity methods
Software	STATA · R · Python · Matlab · oTree · Tableau · Power BI · SAP · Bloomberg NEF · S&P; Commodity Insights

Selected Media & Outreach

RAW Talks Podcast (BGR/Tableau) · Gradwandler Podcast · brandeins · Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung · BSE the Voice · d\carb Future Economy Forum (founder, 2020–present)